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Chapter 11

Telesales Overview



Introduction

In an increasingly competitive sales environment greater emphasis is placed on proactive selling. One of the most potent weapons in the salesperson's armoury is the telephone. It is no longer enough to wait for customers to call or write with the details of an order - everything that can be done to get the order must be done. The costs of trained sales office personnel and telephone charges make it essential every call is productive. The economics of making the calls and sophisticated computer support for the sales staff must be measured and evaluated.

There is a wide range of uses for telesales modules including:

- Cold calling
- Telemarketing
- Taking of an expected order from an existing customer for an agreed list of items.

Each type of call is conducted in a different manner, although common elements of support can be provided by a computer system.

Telesales supports the Sales Operator so that the sales process is fast, accurate and causes the least disruption to both customer and sales office. This requires a structured dialogue, ideally with the buyer and seller using the same "script". This is not possible in a cold call situation, but all of the support information is available to the seller.

The response time from the computer system should be such that it will not normally cause the seller to request the buyer to pause. This performance is related to computer resources but great care has been taken to ensure an optimised screen response time.

Telesales uses a daily list of calls, divided amongst the Telesales operators. Some calls have specific times at which they should be made, others only the date.

Supervisory functions manage and re-assign the work to be done.

Telesales Style

Three distinct styles of Telesales are supported by the module:

- Telesales
- Planned Delivery
- Telemarketing

Telesales

Telesales is where an expected order is being taken from a known customer with an established buying pattern. Telesales generates the call list for the day, identifying the sales operator, time and the sales contacts. When a call is selected, the customer's buying list is displayed. The list of items and the order history is displayed. Selecting a Function Key replaces the order history with price and discount information.

Telesales enables entry of the order information. At the end of the entry of order line information the module displays an order summary. Following the closing of the order the remaining calls are then displayed, allowing the next customer to be selected.

Planned Delivery

Planned delivery is a form of telesales developed for the confectionery / tobacconist wholesale market. In this kind of order entry the customer quotes his current stock levels, module having previously calculated his average weekly demand.

Using this information the quantity to be ordered is calculated and automatically entered as the order quantity. The order closing procedures are as for standard telesales and you can adjust the order quantity if necessary. This ensures a minimum stock holding with little risk of running out of stock.

Telemarketing

In Telemarketing you are contacting customers where the chances of taking an order are very much reduced. You can create a call diary supported by the same call back and reschedule facilities as other areas of Telesales.

It can be seen that the process of referring to a call diary, selecting an account and displaying a definable list of items can support a wide range of telesales activities.

Relationship to Other Modules

Telesales is a standardised product operating under the control of System Manager. Telesales is one of a group of Advanced Module modules which extend the functionality of Base Modules modules.

The following modules are pre-requisites to the operation of Telesales:

- Sales Order Processing
- Inventory Management

If planned delivery is to be used:

- Sales Analysis

The objective of Telesales is to build standard sales orders. All of the standard sales order functions are used to service the order. This includes batch allocation, picking, despatch and invoicing, as well as the full range of enquiries and reports.

As part of the recording of the sales order, the module performs a check on available stock and highlight any shortage conditions. If Planned Delivery is used, then it is necessary to have access to the sales history of a customer so that the average usage for the customer can be calculated; this is derived from the Sales Analysis Database.

Application Configuration

Telesales is multi-company, the characteristics of each company being maintained on a control file. Before a company can be set up Sales Order Processing and Inventory Management must be installed and configured for the company. The control information may then be maintained.

This can be divided into the following classes of data:

Company standard policy controls for:

- Telesales type
- Contact types
- Operator performance and rest periods
- Buying lists
- Target for action messages
- Request for performance statistics

Text:

- Operators
- Call Profiles
- Buying Lists
- Contacts
- Delivery Profiles
- Promotions

Description Identities for:

- Promotion types
- Delivery routes

You can configure the presentation of data in the order recording process, by selecting Presentation Design from the Company Maintenance screen. You can configure, for example, the number of decimal places for the quantity during order entry, the display of the date and the standard concatenation of item number and description.

Maintenance of Reference Data

Common features in the way in which data is maintained are:

- Standard item and customer search routines have been adopted.
- Telesales makes the minimum use of 'codes' and where they are employed a prompt is available to select the correct one.
- Selection is normally from a displayed list or by the entry of a code.

Information for the following may be maintained:

- Operators
- Buying lists
- Customer contacts
- Call profiles
- Sales prompts
- Promotions
- Item families
- Reason descriptions

Operators

All people using Telesales for taking and managing calls must be identified to the module. User details include name and module user ID, as well as standard times; for calls, rest period and the working day, and the type of telesales calls in which the operator is proficient.

The degree of freedom the operator is allowed to change the sequence in which calls are to be made or to divert them to another operator is also maintained.

Buying List

Telesales aims to provide the operator with a list of items to discuss with a Customer. Many companies have a standard list of items which can be used as a basis for a call to most Customers. To enable Telesales to identify the Customers specific requirements, and minimise the call time, certain accounts use bespoke lists. Telesales allows you to create and amend such lists by direct entry or by copying part or all of existing lists.

It is possible to create a list at the appropriate level, and also to automatically build the description of the item that are displayed to the operator. The customer's item number may be displayed as well as the in-house item number.

Customer Contacts

Telesales allows you to create and amend any number of customer contacts. The contact name and details, telephone extension number and comments can be stored. When a call profile is being created the prime contact for that call are selected from the list of contacts.

Call Profiles

Telesales establishes diaries for the calling of customers. There are a number of attributes which can be recorded which are necessary to control the frequency and nature of the calls. They can be conveniently grouped under the following five headings:

- How to contact - telephone, fax, telex numbers
- Whom to contact - preferred or prime contact
- Whose responsibility - sales operator
- Nature of contact - buying list and type of call
- When to contact - time of the day, days of the week and weekly frequency

Full additional text facilities are provided.

Delivery Profiles

Telesales is used to synchronise the customer contact with a delivery pattern. In this way the company can make the best use of its transport expenditure and increase the efficiency of its despatch operation.

As with call profiles the information can be grouped:

- How to contact – telephone, telex, fax
- Whom to contact – primary contact
- When delivery is convenient – times of the day, days of the week and weekly frequency
- Geography – delivery route, drop sequence number

Full additional text facilities are provided.

Sales Prompts

Key reminders are frequently presented to the operator. This might relate to stock shortages or surpluses, pending price changes or general messages. Each message is controlled by an effectivity date. The messages are displayed one at a time, in sequence, at the top of the diary management and order taking screens, so that each time the **Enter** key is pressed the prompt changes.

Promotions

Telesales does not attempt to support and manage all aspects of promotions. It seeks to provide a basic recording of when they take place and the scope and nature of the promotion. The following information can be recorded:

- The promotion type
- The dates when it is operational
- What it is called and its promotion number
- The target increase in sales
- The constraints
- The item which is being promoted or all items
- A specific customer or customer class
- Price list and / or Discount Group
- Combination of customer characteristics

If an item is to be substituted by a promotional item this can be defined on the promotion. This can be used to effect the replacement at order entry if the promotion is accepted.

Item Families

Planned Delivery requires that items are linked together into an item family for the purpose of analysing sales in generic markets. This is achieved by creating a family like a Bill of Materials.

For example; a family could have a base item of vanilla and any number of promotion items or flavours. All items both base and promotion must be complete items defined to Inventory Management. Families are set up and maintained directly or are automatically created by defining a promotion with a promotional item.

Reason Descriptions

Telesales can set objectives for the Sales Operators and exercises a degree of control and measurement over their performance. If an operator is unable, either by typing in a code or selecting one from a list, to achieve the expected action at the expected time they are required to give a reason. Reason codes appropriate for the company can be set-up and maintained as required.

Generate Call Lists

This is normally run at the end of each working day to prepare the call list up to a specified date. The following actions can be performed as part of this run:

- Make an entry in the call list for all call profiles with a date, less than or equal to the specified date of the run.
- Generate a skeleton order based upon the nominated buying list for the call profile.
- Generate the prices and discounts for the customer / items on the buying list.
- Generate order history for the specified number of weeks or orders.

The first two of these are always performed, while pricing and order history are done if requested. The defaults for their inclusion in the run are on the company control file. You can balance the work load between call list generation and response times by changing the run time parameters to try different combinations .

Manage Call Lists

You can manage the Call Lists using the options below. Each operator has an authority level reflecting the options they can use. The following authority levels are available:

- 0 - The Operator must take the next call in sequence.
- 1 - The Operator may take any call next.
- 2 - The Operator may amend the time of the call.
- 3 - The Operator may change who is to make a call.

Operators can use options below their level, i.e. a user authorised to option 2 also has access to option 1. Two lists are created, both sequenced by Operator and Date. Timed calls are added to one and untimed to the other. The Call List is displayed with timed calls at the top and untimed at the bottom.

Telesales takes the average call time for the operator and adds it to the current time. If no timed calls are due by the calculated time, it selects an untimed call. This calculation is performed each time the screen is selected or the Refresh option is taken. Similarly each time the Call Selection screen is displayed one of the Sales Prompts is displayed. Only operators with an authority level of 3 can re-organise and redistribute the call list of another operator. If a call is selected but contact is not completed the operators can request call back at a specified time.

Record Order Details

Once a Customer has been selected the module enters the appropriate style of order entry:

- 1 - Telesales.
- 2 - Planned delivery.
- 3 - Telemarketing.

The top part of the screen contains key customer information, including contact name and extension number. The left hand side of the screen contains the item identification. For each item the Telesales function creates a 30-character identifier made up of item number and description as required. Order details are entered in a column; either order quantity or current stock level in the case of Planned Delivery.

On the right hand side is previous order data for Telesales, average order information for Planned Delivery or price and discount data. Function keys toggle between the Price / Discount and History / Average screen and back. These screens enable order details to be entered extremely quickly, therefore pressing **Enter** normally displays the next screen.

At the end of the item screens the module presents a summary which:

- Displays the details of the order lines taken. In the case of planned delivery it includes the calculated order quantity.
- Displays the price and discount.
- Allows the entry of additional items.
- Performs a credit check.
- Demands entry of customer order entry reference.
- Quotes the order number.
- Allows additional charges to be appended to the order.
- Allows entry of order date and due delivery date for the order.
- Tests the free stock to confirm despatch can be made.
- Provides for confirmation of the next call details.

You can display buying lists, including the description of the list, e.g. Small Electrical Wholesalers-Brown Goods. These lists are not static - they might contain those items which should be pushed to a particular market sector today.

Create Sales Orders

Recording order details updates an order work file. The data in this work file is used to create the information required to allow allocation, picking and despatch to be handled by standard Sales Order Processing functions.

This function exists in the Telesales sub-system, is activated by the ending of a call and creates an order within a few minutes.

Work Planning

Telesales displays the work to be done by Operator by day, in bar chart form . This includes the standard rest period. This enquiry enables class three operators to replan work.

Performance Analysis

If enabled in your Company Profile, performance statistics are recorded. The elapsed time for each stage of the order taking cycle and the number of lines taken is recorded. The performance analysis report then gives Operator Performance information at summary or detail level between a range of dates.

Preparing to Use Telesales

Setting up Telesales requires careful planning and preparation. Your existing Telesales procedures and data need to be transferred to the module. Consideration should also be given to improvements which could be made to current procedures by making full use of the capabilities of Telesales.

When Telesales is installed, four major areas must be considered.

- Have the prerequisite modules been installed and if so are they set up in a way which is suitable for the operation of Telesales?
- How the functions and facilities of Telesales are used to enhance the selling activity of the company?
- Has the operation of Telesales been discussed with customers?
- Have the operators of the module had adequate education?

Links to Modules

Telesales relies heavily on data held in other modules and its objective is to generate orders in a standard form within Sales Order Processing. Sales Order Processing must be installed with all its prerequisites and conditions satisfied.

The two character company code in Telesales identifies which Sales Order Processing, Inventory Management, Accounts Receivable and Sales Analysis company it is linked to.

A number of Telesales functions depend directly on data held in other modules. These are:

- Previous Order History data can be displayed to the operator. This is extracted from the Sales Order Processing database.
- Pricing and discounting information used in Telesales is retrieved from Sales Order Processing.
- Customer information such as supplying depot, price list, discount list and currency is retrieved from Sales Order Processing.
- Stock levels used in sourcing and availability checks are from the Inventory Management module.
- Data from Sales Analysis is used to calculate average weekly sales.

How Will The Telesales Module Be Used?

Telesales is designed to record order requirements quickly, while talking to a customer. To achieve this a pre-agreed list of items is displayed to the operator to offer to the customer, the only entry required being the order quantity. Telesales allows three variations on this basic theme. These methods should be fully understood so that the appropriate technique can be used with each customer. The following questions should be asked:

- Which style of telesales is used for each customer?
- Will standard buying lists be created or will they be customer specific?
- Will operators work in small groups on a list of customers or will they each have their own customer list?
- Will the module be used to time and record the performance of each operator?

Discussion With Customers

In order to gain the maximum benefit from Telesales customers should understand the nature of the dialogue you plan to have with them. They should understand you intend to sell from a list and should perhaps have a copy of the list. If you are using Planned Delivery with them they must understand they are expected to give current stock levels and must have complete confidence in the re-order level algorithm used.

Are The Operators Trained?

As Telesales directly affects your relationships with your customers the only change they should see is improvement. It is imperative that operators are trained to use the module.

It is both practical and desirable to introduce a pilot scheme with a small number of carefully selected customers.

Basic Data

Having decided how you will use Telesales in conjunction with other modules and the companies you will use, you need to plan and implement the setting up of the additional data required. The main elements you need to create are:

- Company Profile
- Operator Profiles
- Buying Lists
- Customer Contacts
- Call Profiles
- Promotions
- Reason Codes

Company Profile

The Telesales module will make use of information held on the Sales Order Processing and Inventory company profiles. Additional information is also required.

Defaults for the operation of Telesales:

- Type of order (telesales, telemarketing, planned delivery)
- Buying list
- Time of pricing
- Stock availability check
- Names to be used in dates, e.g. January, February etc. and Monday, Tuesday etc.
- Formatting at the order line entry screen
- Controlling the logic to decide on the next call to be taken

Operator Profiles

In many Telesales operations an operator owns a number of customers so that a rapport may be established. It is possible to define operators to the system so that when they choose to start making calls their list is displayed to them. This can be extended so that a group of operators own a list of customers. The operator can have the authority to make a decision about their work load and the sequence in which calls are to be taken.

Buying Lists

A buying list is the list of items to be discussed with the customer during a call. It can be a short customer specific list, or the full catalogue of the company's range. Care must be taken to ensure that most of the items required are on the list, however, if the catalogue approach is used the preparation of the call list may be protracted.

Customer Contacts

In order that the sales call can be most effective it should be made to a previously agreed, named individual or contact. Text can be added to the basic details to aid the reinforcement of the relationship.

Call Profiles

The Call Profile records that a named individual in your company should telephone a named individual at the customer to discuss a list of items. This call should be made at previously agreed dates and times to record their requirements by either taking order quantities or the current stock levels. There are a number of points to watch carefully:

- The calls must be smoothed over the week and day as much as possible.
- Calls must be spread evenly between operators over the course of the day.
- All operators should have a number of untimed calls to fill in the blank times.
- A customer can have more than one call profile to discuss different lists, or to allow for call patterns which are not based just on a weekly cycle.

Promotions

In general promotions advise or act as a reminder except when an item substitution is made. In this case the promoted item is substituted if the promotion option is taken. Care must be taken when analysing sales of the base item and the substituted item.

Reason Codes

Two character reason codes can be set up to help analyse the reason for failed calls. Care should be taken to restrict the number to help operators.

Initial Data Take On

Once the additional data has been set-up you are ready to use the module to receive calls and record orders using Telesales. In order to make outgoing calls, run the call list generation procedure. This builds the list of calls to make and create a rapid reference database of the previous orders for the items on the buying list for the required customers. This can be a very large task if there are:

- A large number of customers
- A large number of lines on the buying lists
- A large number of weeks history required

In general the product of:

- Customers
- Buying list lines
- Number of weeks orders gives the number of order lines to be built into the history. It is estimated that this could be done at about 25,000 per hour although this will vary depending upon machine size and other activity.